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CENTRE OF EXCELLENCE
The WII trains wildlife biologists who undertake research across India

WILDLIFE INSTITUTE

CAGING RESEARCHERS

By Rahul Noronha

For a reputed research institution known across the world, the Dehradun-based Wildlife Institute of India (WII) is going through unusually tough times. An autonomous institution under the Union ministry of environment, forests and climate change (MoEFCC), that trains wildlife biologists who undertake research across India, the WII has been facing a funds crunch—with reduced allocation in the Union budget for it and similar institutes—in recent years that has been hampering its functioning. But now comes the deepest cut of all. The MoEFCC has asked the WII to send its reports and studies to the ministry before releasing them elsewhere. The move has academics worried, with some seeing it as a 'gag order' that encroaches on WII's rights, curtailing the independence of its opinion.

The April 18 letter from the MoEFCC, addressed to the director of WII, states that scientific studies and assessments on species and habitats that the WII carries out for various ministries are published as knowledge products and documents. Further, it states that the reports contain recommendations/ observations on activities for which permission is needed from the Union government under the Wildlife Protection Act (WPA), 1972. Some reports also have a bearing on policy issues pertaining to wildlife conservation. Considering all this, the ministry has asked the WII to seek its approval before releasing any report on matters where permission under the WPA is to be accorded by the Centre or which is concerned with policy issues on wildlife.

The ministry has rationalised the move by saying that the ADG of Forests (Wildlife) is in charge of wildlife preservation and needs to know about WII reports. The ministry not only wants to vet publications and reports in the future, but also wants to scrutinise reports released in the past.

At the WII, no academic would openly criticise the order, but there is disagreement in the air. "The ministry wants to control scientific opinion. This is not done anywhere in the world and would undermine WII's credibility," says an academic. "Some WII reports on wildlife have gone against the plans of top politicians and have been an impediment in the pursuit of business goals," adds another.

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The WII gave the go-ahead to the translocation of Asiatic Lions from Gujarat's Gir to Kuno Palpur in Madhya Pradesh. The plan is stuck in the face of protests from the Gujarat government. Similarly, a WII report on the Great Indian Bustard had termed power transmission lines as the single biggest threat to the bird. A Supreme Court bench headed by then CJI S.A. Bobde had in April 2021 ruled that transmission lines be moved underground in bustard habitats. The Union ministries of renewable energy, power and environment filed a petition in the SC in December 2021, asking it to modify its order. The WII also gave the feasibility report on the introduction of cheetahs from Africa at Kuno Palpur, besides reports on elephant corridors.

"Clearly, what is not agreeable will not be approved, even though it may be an accurate, honest opinion," says a wildlife scientist. "This move sets a bad precedent. It would curtail academic freedom and adversely impact independent research. Most research funding comes from the government, but that should not be a reason for influencing its outcome," says Dr Mewa Singh, professor emeritus at Mysore University, who is associated with the WII.

"WII has reputed staff biologists with domain knowledge of wildlife. Its reports are used by the government, its statutory bodies, even by courts. The cheetah reintroduction, the first time a large carnivore is being shifted across continents, is based on a report of the WII. Given this background, the ministry may want to reconsider its move," says environmental historian Mahesh Rangarajan.

The WII releases around 30-40 papers and an equal number of reports every year on wildlife issues. ■